

Ratatosk's Muddled Message

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two wise ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, thinks things through, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being clever and brave and kind, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.



Ratatosk's Muddled Message

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The Great World Tree is huge. It goes from deep roots far below to a high nest right at the top. All day, a quick red squirrel runs up and down it, carrying everyone's messages. His name is Ratatosk.

But today something has gone wrong. Ratatosk has muddled all the messages up! Now the great Eagle at the very top thinks a small friend down in the roots said something unkind. And the small friend thinks the Eagle said something unkind too. Neither of them did. It was only a mix-up. But now the two old friends are cross, and the whole tree feels sad.

Edda the Saga-Keeper calls you to the warm Hearth Hall. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she says. "Will you help Ratatosk sort his messages and set things right, so the two friends are friends again?"

She gives you three gifts: a ball of red yarn, a snack for the squirrel, and a little lantern. Then she smiles. "Up here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Wit, of Courage, or of Heart?

Stop 1: Catch the Squirrel

You step out under the Great World Tree. There is Ratatosk, zooming up and down, round and round, far too flustered to stop. "Sorry, sorry, no time, all muddled!" he chatters as he whizzes past.

He is in such a flap that he cannot help anyone, not even himself. He needs to slow down and rest.

How could you help him feel calm? You have a snack for the squirrel. Could you sit very still and speak softly? Could you watch which way he runs and wait for the right moment?

When you hold out the snack and speak gently, Ratatosk stops at last. He nibbles, he breathes, and his little heart slows down. "Thank you," he sighs. "Now I can think."

Stop 2: Sort the Messages

Ratatosk opens his paws, and out tumble three little messages, all in a jumble. There are three friends waiting: the Eagle at the top, a wise old owl on a middle branch, and the small friend down in the roots. Each message belongs to one of them, but which goes where?

The Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, land beside you. They like to give a hint to heroes who try hard.

Can you remember who lives where? Read each message and look for a clue. One talks about the wind up high. One talks about the deep dark roots. One hoots a friendly hello. Which friend does each one belong to?

When you match every message to the right friend, the muddle melts away. "That's it! That's it!" cheers Ratatosk, clapping his little paws. Now you know exactly what to carry, and to whom.

Stop 3: Climb and Deliver

There is one more thing to do. The right message must go all the way up to the Eagle, and the right message all the way down to the small friend, so they each understand at last.

The tree is tall, and the climb is high. But you have your ball of red yarn.

How will you climb safely and not get lost? Could you tie the red yarn at the bottom, like a safety line, and follow it as you go? Could you light your little lantern for the dark deep roots?

When you tie on the red yarn and climb carefully, you reach the Eagle high above. You read out the kind, true message. The Eagle's fierce frown softens. "Oh!" he says. "So my friend was never unkind at all." Then you follow the yarn down, down, down to the roots, lantern glowing, and tell the small friend the same. The small friend's eyes go wide and happy.

Friends Again

The Eagle spreads his great wings and waves from the top of the tree. Far below, the small friend waves right back, and they both call out, "Friends again!"

Ratatosk runs a happy loop around the whole tree. "You sorted my muddle and mended my friends," he says. "Thank you, thank you!"

High above the snowy fjords, Freya the Kind looks down and smiles. You did it together. You were clever, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes gently coaxing a flustered red squirrel to stop, holding out a snack, message scrolls scattered in the snow.



Two small heroes and a red squirrel sorting little message scrolls laid out on the snow, matching each to a picture.



Two small heroes climbing the snowy branches of the great world tree to deliver a scroll, two friendly ravens guiding the way.



A great eagle high in the world tree and a small friend among the roots, reconciled and waving, a happy squirrel between them and two heroes cheering.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Version 1, updated 2026-06-03, en-GB



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